

A Choice-Based Conjoint Analysis of Forcetek Men's Jerseys

Marketing Analytics
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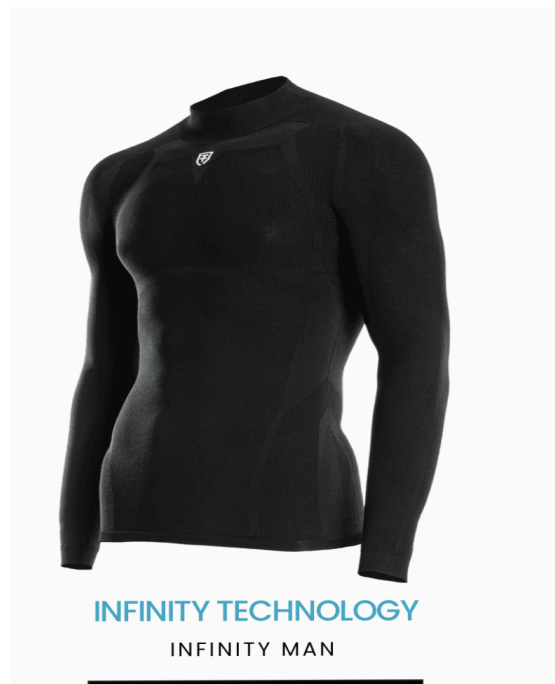
1. Introduction

The global sportswear industry has undergone a period of rapid expansion, fueled by a heightening consumer focus on personal fitness, increased participation in recreational sports, and the rise of lifestyle-oriented athletic apparel. In this increasingly competitive landscape, simply providing quality is no longer sufficient; brands must develop a deep understanding of evolving consumer preferences to create products that resonate with specific purchasing behaviors. This is particularly evident in the sports jersey category, where decision-making is driven by a complex interaction between functional performance, aesthetic design, pricing strategy, and brand positioning.

This research was conducted to provide strategic support for the product development and marketing initiatives of **Forcetek**, a prominent Italian sportswear brand. Forcetek operates as the technical apparel division of **La Griffe srl**, an organization with over three decades of specialized experience in manufacturing high-performance garments for the Italian Armed Forces and State Police (La Griffe srl, 2024). By leveraging this "battle-tested" heritage and a commitment to 100% "Made in Italy" craftsmanship, the brand seeks to further solidify its presence in the consumer athletic market.

The primary objective of this study is to identify the critical product attributes of Forcetek Men's jersey that govern consumer choice and to quantify the specific trade-offs individuals are willing to make between these features during the purchasing process.

To achieve these objectives, a Choice-Based Conjoint (CBC) analysis was employed using primary data gathered from a global survey of active consumers. This report details the methodology of the study, provides an intensive analysis of the trade-offs identified, and concludes with strategic recommendations for Forcetek's branding and production units



2. Methodology

Conjoint analysis serves as the foundation of this study, allowing for the estimation of consumer preference structures by quantifying how individuals value specific product features in combination. By analyzing these trade-offs, we can decompose a product into its "part-worth utilities" across five primary attributes: **price, material composition, color design, country of origin, and purchasing channel availability**. To provide a holistic view of the market, the survey supplemented these Choice-Based Conjoint (CBC) tasks with the collection of demographic and behavioral data, enabling a deeper understanding of the target consumer profile.

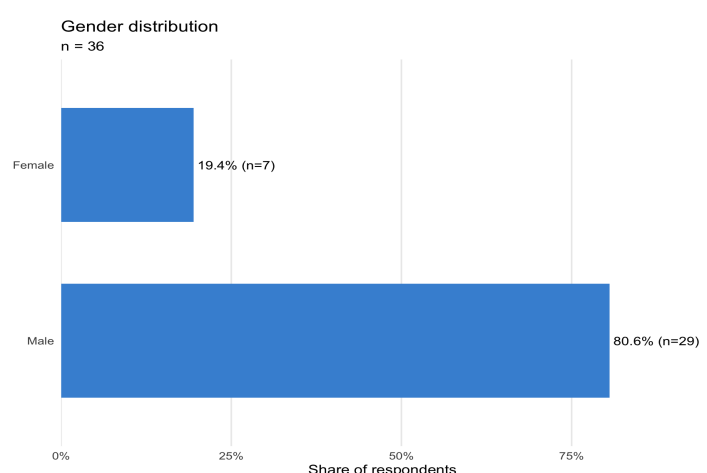
To ensure the study remained grounded in market reality, the CBC levels were anchored to the current brand positioning of **Forcetek**. The pricing attribute was developed around a baseline of **€139**, reflecting the brand's current (January 2026) online retail price. This was expanded into a range of **€65 to €185**, utilizing €40 intervals to test price elasticity and willingness to pay.

The aesthetic and technical configurations were similarly rooted in existing and potential offerings. For color design, we tested the current market standard, "**Stealth Black**," against a version with blue trims in breathable areas and a "full color" blue alternative. The material composition focused on four key textiles: **polypropylene, polyester, nylon, and wool**. A critical component of the study was the "**Made in Italy**" attribute, designed to test the strength of Forcetek's 100% Italian branding and determine its actual relevance to the consumer's decision-making process. Finally, we evaluated online sales platforms as the primary purchasing channels. While physical retail remains a relevant variable, we focused exclusively on e-commerce to reflect a **cost-efficient distribution model**, specifically targeting the reduced storage and management expenses of online platforms

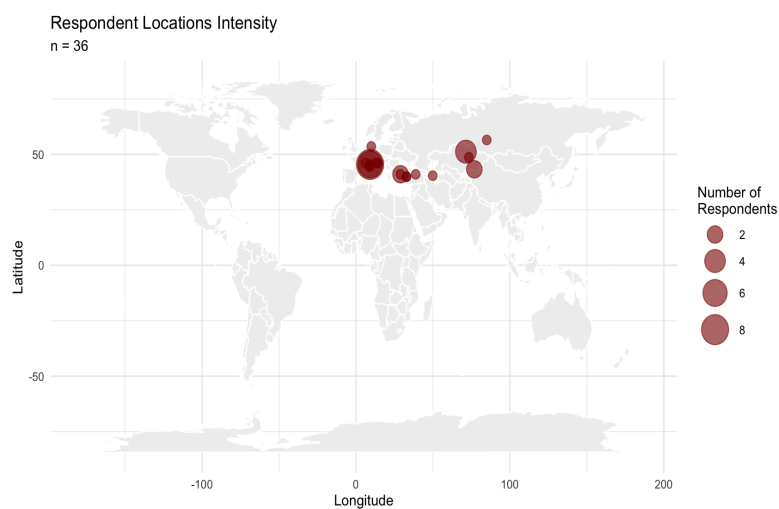
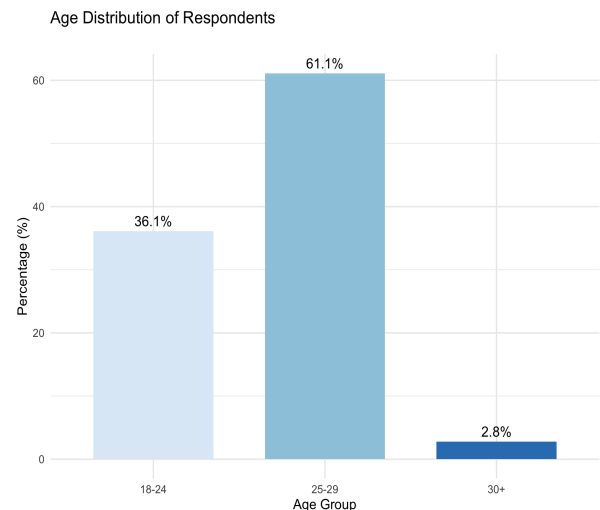
3. Results and Data Analysis

3.1 Demographic Data

The study sample is composed of 36 valid respondents. The gender distribution of respondents shows a strong skew toward male participants. This distribution is largely consistent with the focus of the study on **men's sport jerseys**, indicating that the survey successfully reached its primary target audience. The dominance of male respondents suggests that the conjoint results primarily reflect preferences, trade-offs, and purchase drivers relevant to male consumers.



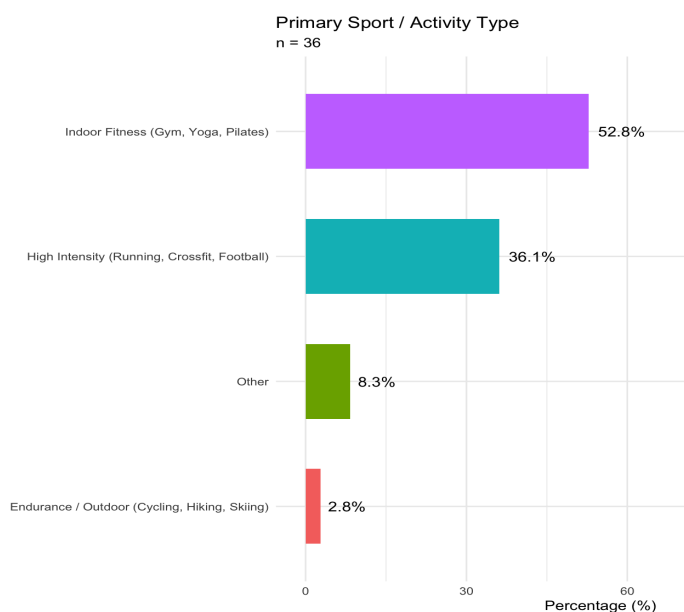
The vast majority of respondents (**61.1%**) fall into the 25–29 age bracket. More than a third of the sample (**36.1%**) is composed of younger adults aged 18–24. Only a very small fraction of the sample (**2.8%**) is aged 30 or older.



While Forcetek’s primary market is Italy, it is important to note that approximately one-third of the current sample consists of respondents from Asia.

Consequently, the findings do not exclusively represent the Italian market. The results should be interpreted with caution, taking into account potential regional variances in consumer tastes, cultural preferences, and purchasing behaviors.

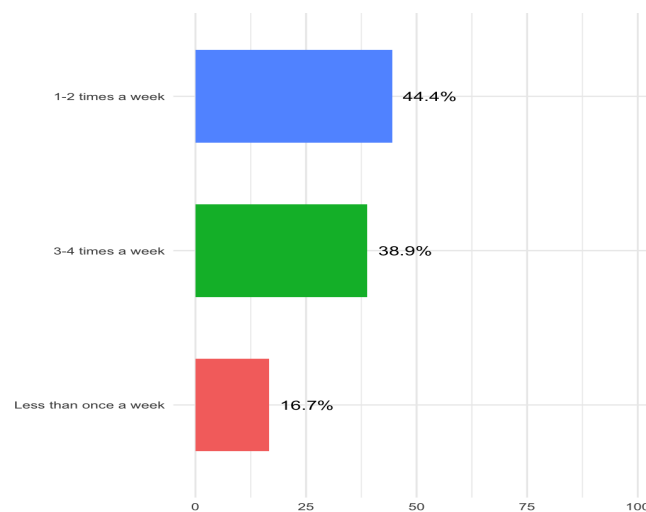
3.2. Behavioural characteristics of Respondents



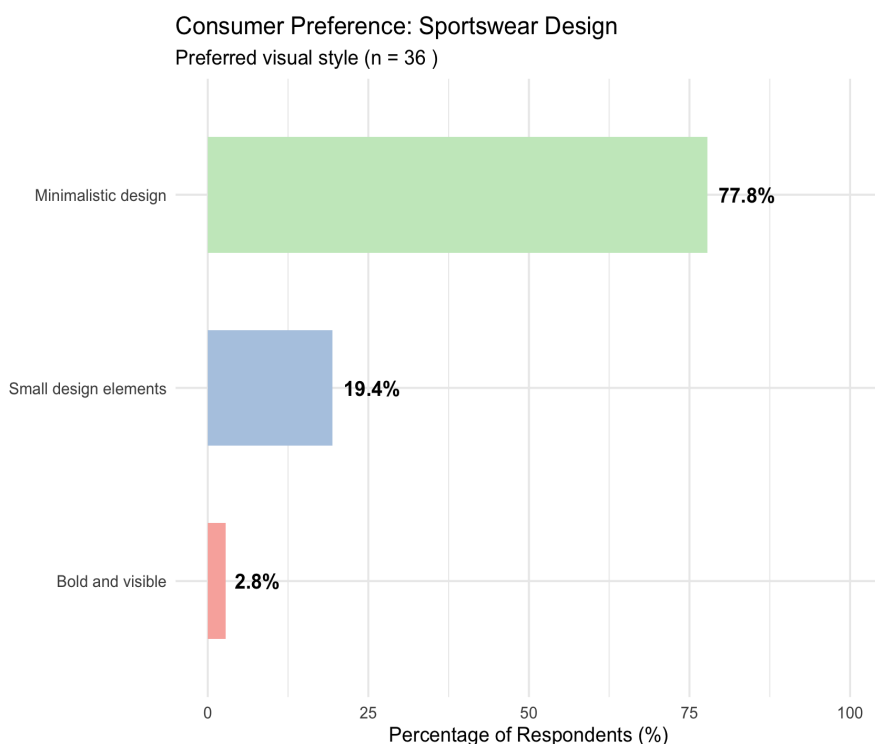
The distribution of primary sport or activity types shows that **indoor fitness activities dominate the sample**. A majority of respondents (**52.8%**) identified indoor fitness activities such as gym training, yoga, or pilates as their primary form of physical activity. This is followed by **high-intensity sports** (e.g., running, CrossFit, football), which account for **36.1%** of responses.

Smaller segments of respondents reported participation in **endurance or outdoor activities (2.8%)**, while **8.3%** selected other activities.

The data indicates that the surveyed population primarily engages in structured, facility-based fitness activities and high-intensity training. Consequently, the preferences identified in the conjoint experiment are likely driven by needs for **durability, thermoregulation in controlled environments, and frequent laundering cycles**. Furthermore, the **Sports Participation Frequency** data, as can be seen in the Figure below, confirms an absence of professional-level athletes, indicating that our findings reflect the requirements of the high-frequency amateur and recreational segment rather than highly specialized professional practitioners.



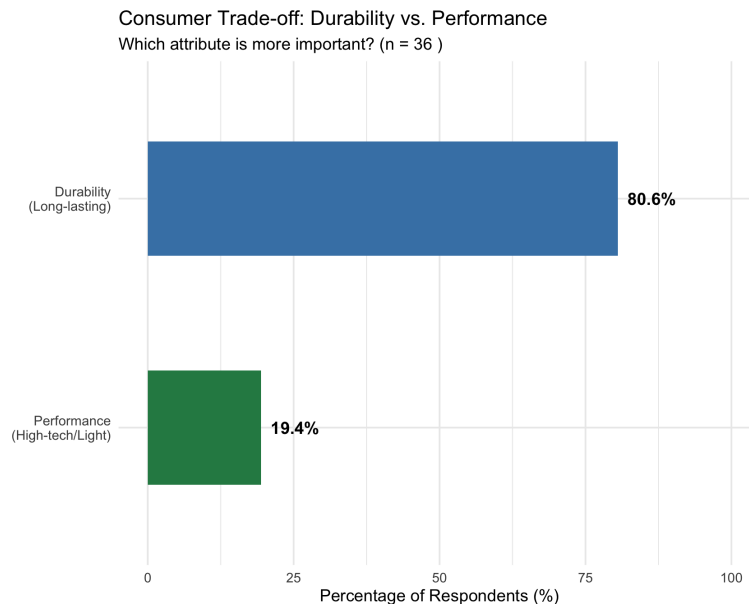
3.3. Consumer Preferences:



The results for sportswear design preferences reveal a strong inclination toward **minimalistic design**. A clear majority of respondents (**77.8%**) indicated a preference for minimalistic sportswear, characterized by clean aesthetics and understated visuals. **19.4%** of respondents preferred designs with small design elements, while only **2.8%** expressed a preference

for **bold and highly visible** designs.

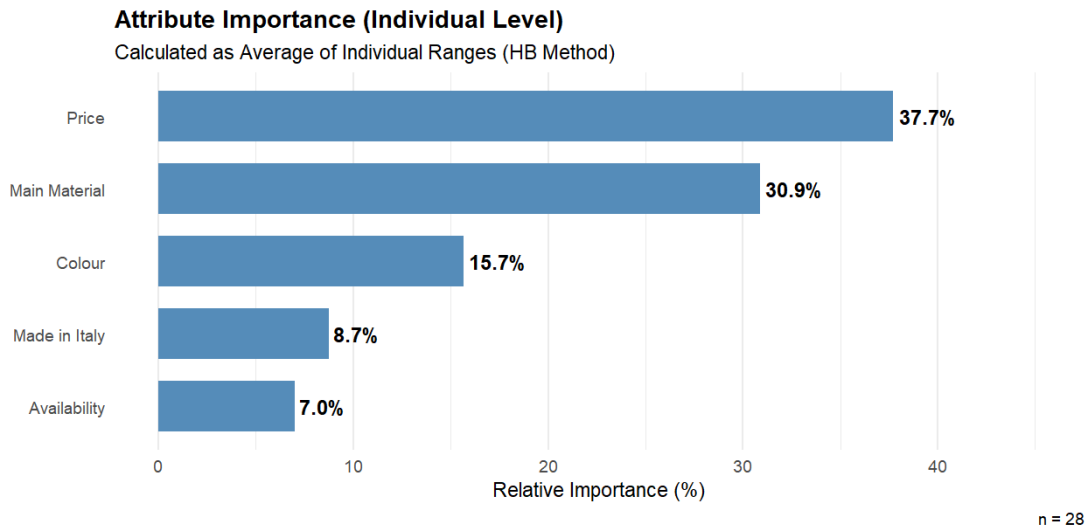
The dominance of minimalistic preferences suggests that visual simplicity plays an important role in perceived suitability for regular training and everyday sports use. Consequently, the design-related choices observed in the conjoint experiment are likely influenced by an understated visual identity rather than strong stylistic expression.



Analysis reveals a decisive preference for **durability** over specialized performance. A significant **80.6%** of respondents prioritized long-term product integrity, while only **19.4%** favored lightweight or advanced technical features that might reduce lifespan.

These results suggest that consumers view high-quality sportswear as a **long-term investment** rather than a disposable performance tool. Forcetek can leverage this by emphasizing its "battle-tested" longevity and Italian craftsmanship, aligning its marketing with the clear demand for **consistent quality and reliability** across repeated use.

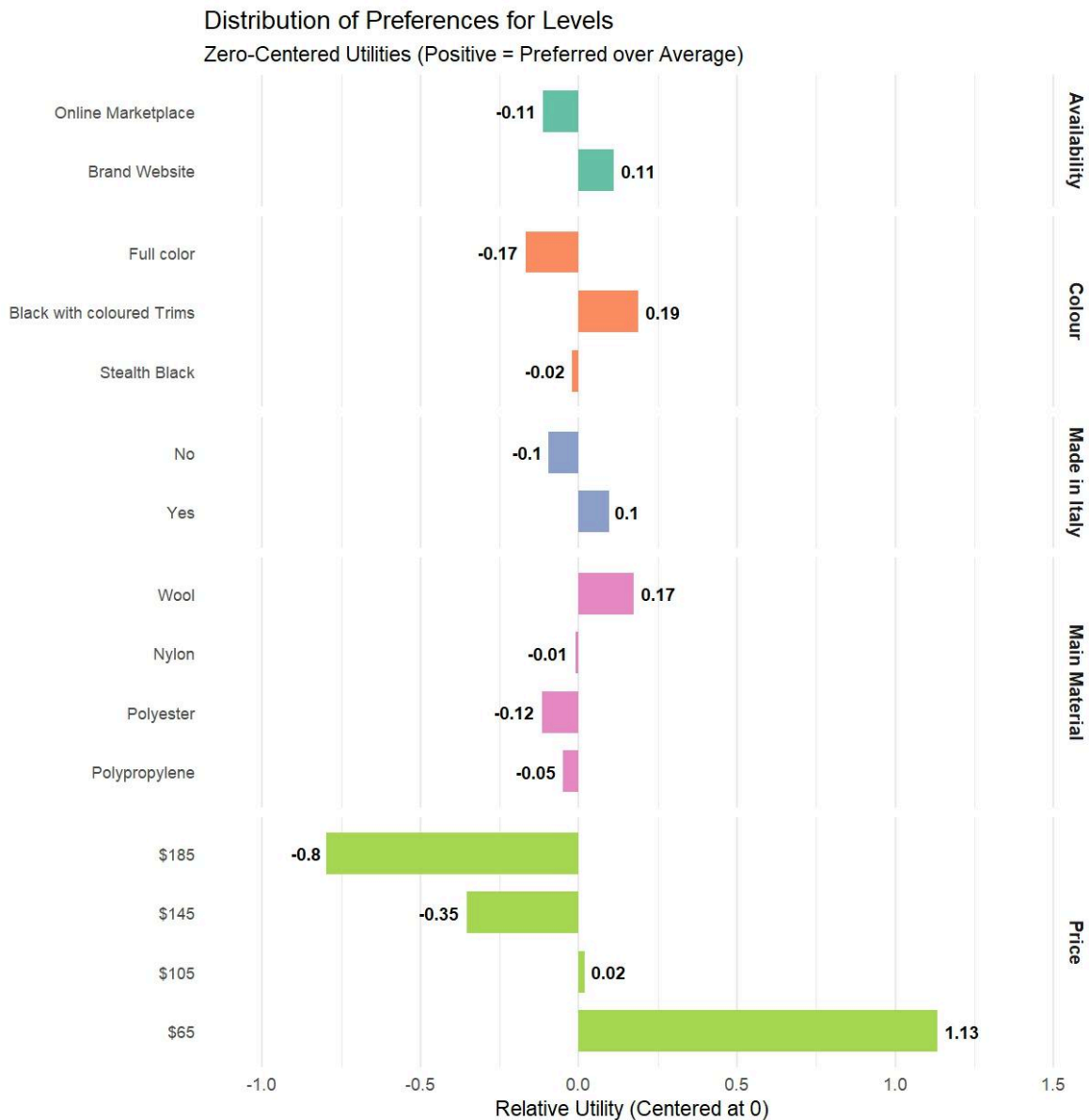
3.4. Attribute importance



The conjoint analysis reveals that consumer decision-making for Forcetek's jerseys is primarily driven by a rational evaluation of economic and functional utility, with **Price** (37.7%) and **Main Material** (30.9%) collectively accounting for nearly 70% of the total relative importance. While **Color** (15.7%) maintains a moderate influence on aesthetic appeal, branding and logistical factors such as **"Made in Italy" origin** (8.7%) and **Online Availability** (7.0%) play significantly smaller roles in the final purchase choice. These results suggest that the target segment views the product as a long-term functional investment, prioritizing a competitive price-to-quality ratio over secondary prestige or distribution attributes. Consequently, trade-offs are predominantly shaped by price sensitivity and technical fabric preferences, positioning aesthetic design and origin as supporting rather than primary drivers of market success.

3.5. Preference For Levels

Considering the average consumer, what levels do they prefer?



The level preference results illustrate how individual attribute levels influence the average consumer's choice relative to other levels within the same attribute. Since the values are zero-centered, positive values indicate stronger consumer preference, while negative values represent lower attractiveness.

For **price**, the results demonstrate a clear inverse relationship between cost and consumer preference. The lowest price level, **\$65**, shows the strongest positive preference (**+1.13**), indicating that affordability strongly increases purchase likelihood. The **\$105** price level maintains a slightly positive preference (**+0.02**) suggesting it remains acceptable for many consumers. In contrast, higher price points show increasing dispreference, with **\$145 (-0.35)** and especially **\$185 (-0.8)** significantly reducing purchase appeal.

For **colour**, respondents show the highest preference for jerseys featuring **black with coloured trims for breathable zones (+0.19)**, followed by **Stealth Black (-0.02)**. Conversely, **full colour designs (-0.17)** are associated with lower consumer preference,

suggesting that respondents favor subtle or performance-oriented colour schemes rather than highly vibrant or visually dominant designs.

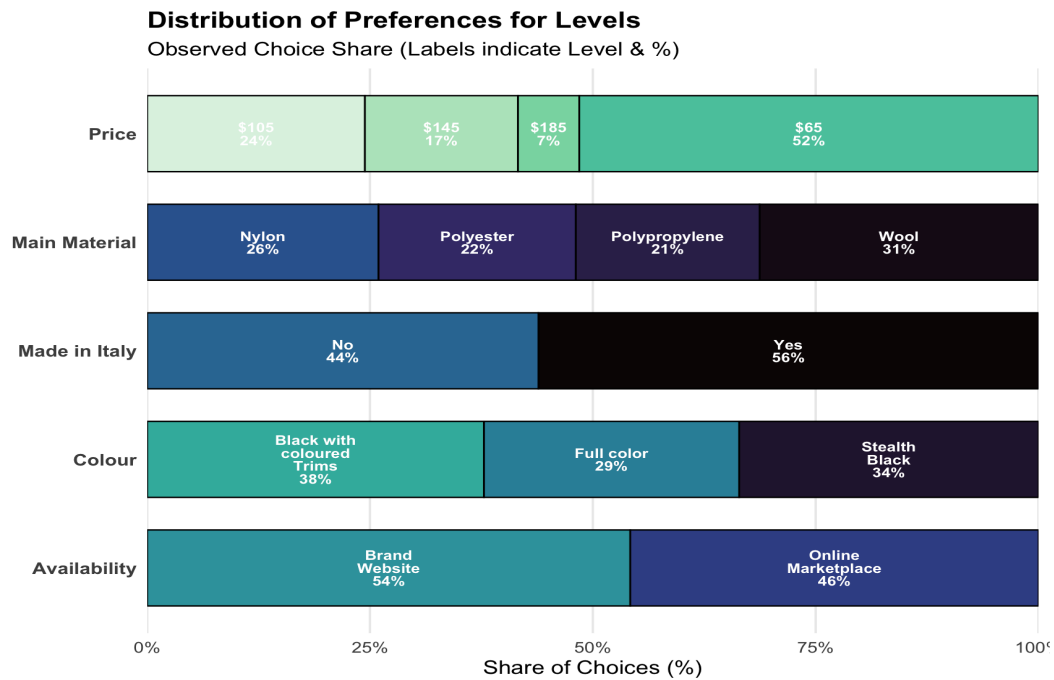
Regarding **main material**, **wool (+0.17)** demonstrates the strongest positive preference among evaluated fabrics. The remaining materials receive slightly negative or neutral preference scores, with **polyester (-0.12)** showing the lowest preference, followed by **polypropylene (-0.05)** and **nylon (-0.01)**, which appears largely neutral in consumer perception.

For **country of origin**, respondents show a moderate preference for products labeled **Made in Italy (+0.1)**, while jerseys without this designation demonstrate a corresponding dispreference **(-0.1)**. This suggests that local or premium origin branding contributes positively to product evaluation, although its influence remains moderate compared to price or material.

Finally, in terms of **online availability**, respondents slightly prefer purchasing through a **brand website (+0.11)**, while purchasing through **online marketplaces (-0.11)** appears somewhat less attractive. This result suggests a mild trust or brand authenticity effect associated with direct brand purchasing channels.

Overall, these results indicate that consumers place strong emphasis on price accessibility, show clear aesthetic preferences for understated colour designs, and demonstrate *measurable* sensitivity to material choice and product origin. These level-based preferences provide deeper insight into how individual product configurations influence overall purchase likelihood within the conjoint framework.

Considering that each consumer likes (slightly or greatly) different levels, what is the distribution of preferences for different levels (within each attribute) across consumers?



This figure demonstrates how preference shares are spread among respondents rather than focusing only on the average consumer. It highlights the extent of agreement or heterogeneity in preferences within each attribute.

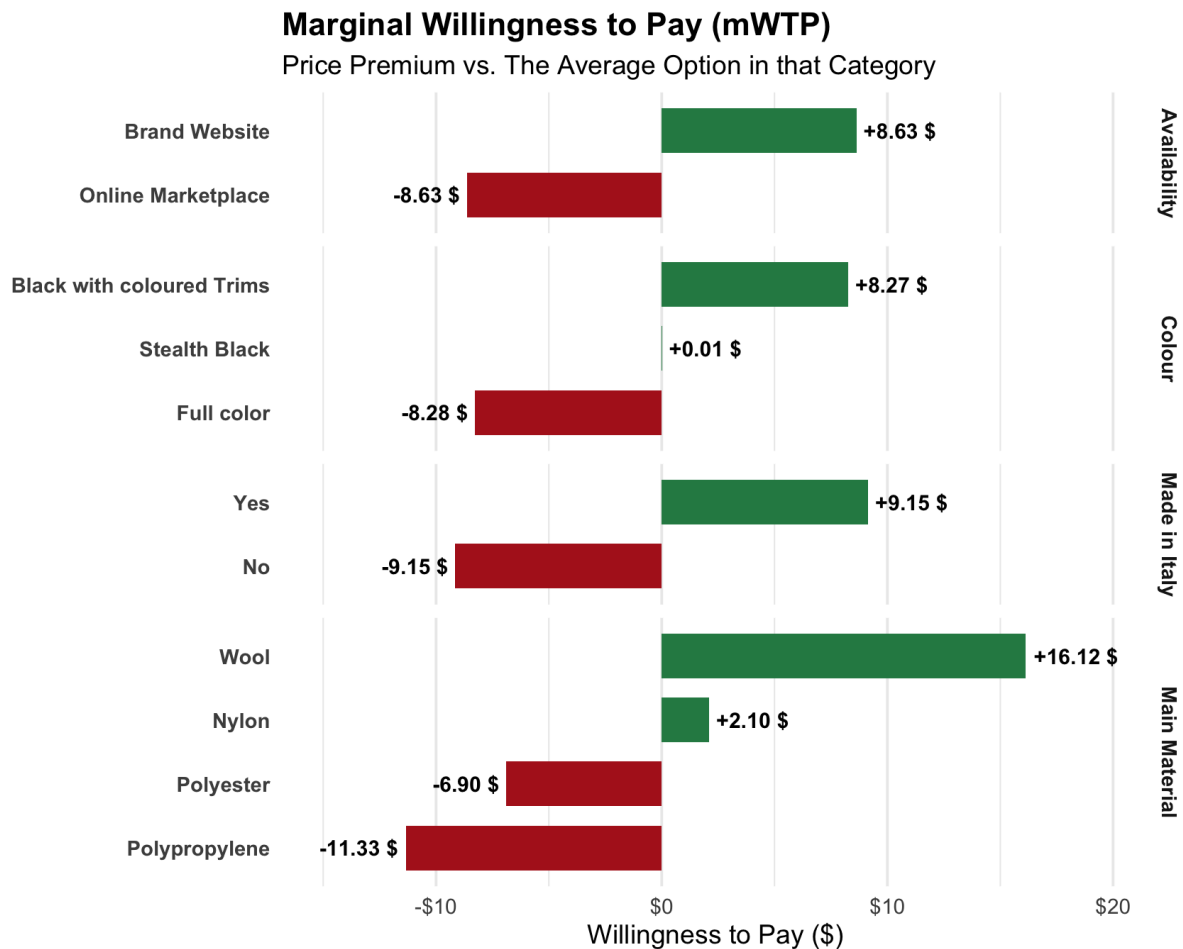
Overall, this distribution highlights differences in consensus across attributes. Price preferences appear highly concentrated, indicating strong agreement among consumers, while attributes such as colour and material show greater preference diversity, suggesting the presence of multiple consumer sub-segments with distinct product expectations.

Taking the example of Price, 52% of consumers prefer to pay \$65, which is the lowest price we offered for the Jersey. This indicates an inclination to the product that costs less. To check for price sensitivity, we plotted the average preference depending on price and obtained the following graph, which shows negative proportionality within the two variables.



Overall, the chart highlights pronounced **price sensitivity** within the sample. Consumers exhibit a strong preference for lower-priced jerseys and demonstrate decreasing willingness to accept higher prices, reinforcing the central role of price as a key driver of choice in the conjoint analysis.

3.6. Marginal Willingness to Pay



The **Marginal Willingness to Pay (mWTP)** analysis estimates the monetary value consumers assign to specific product features relative to the average option within each attribute category. Positive mWTP values indicate that consumers are willing to pay a premium above the category average for a given feature, while negative values indicate that consumers require a price reduction relative to the average to consider that feature equally attractive.

For **colour**, results indicate clear differentiation in economic value across design alternatives. Jerseys featuring **black with coloured trims for breathable zones** generate a positive mWTP of approximately **+\$8.27**, suggesting that consumers are willing to pay a premium relative to the average colour option. **Stealth Black** appears economically **neutral** (**+\$0.01**), indicating valuation close to the category mean. In contrast, **full colour** designs show a negative mWTP of approximately **−\$8.28**, implying that consumers require price compensation for this more visually expressive option. Overall, subtle performance-oriented colour schemes are economically preferred.

For **main material**, **wool** demonstrates the strongest positive economic value, with an mWTP of approximately **+\$16.12** relative to the average material. **Nylon** also carries a positive

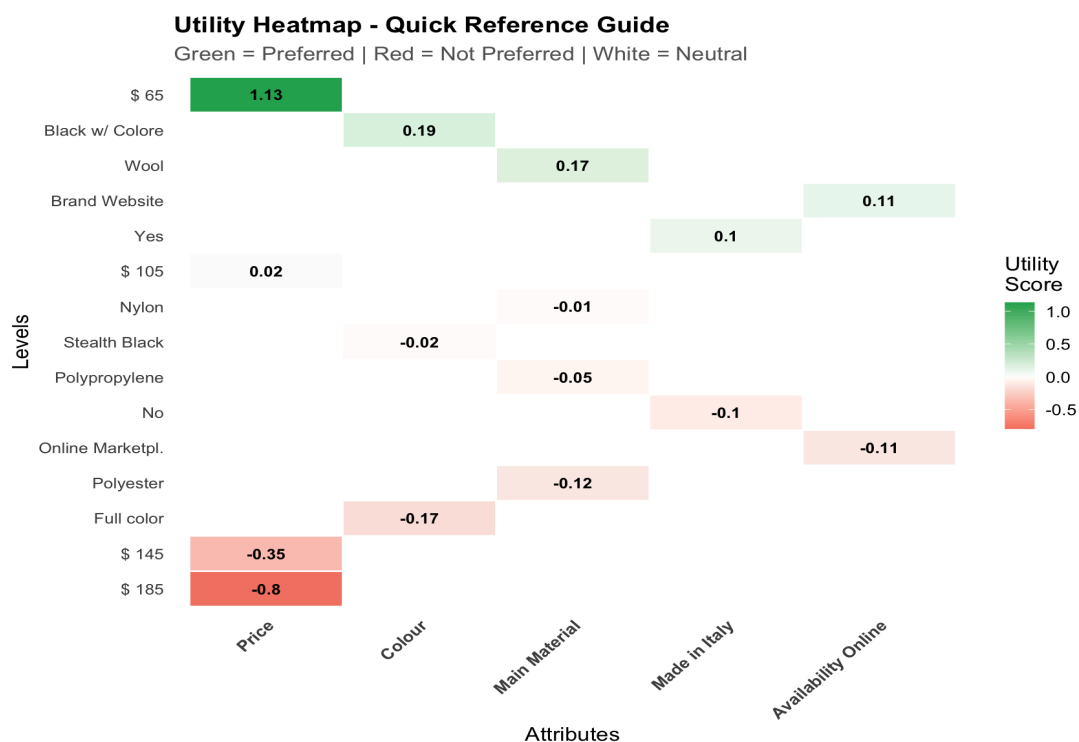
premium of **+\$2.10**, suggesting moderate added value. Conversely, **polyester (−\$6.90)** and **polypropylene (−\$11.33)** exhibit negative mWTP values, indicating that these materials reduce perceived product value relative to the average. These findings suggest a strong consumer preference for natural materials, particularly wool.

Regarding **country of origin**, products labeled **Made in Italy** show a positive mWTP of approximately **+\$9.15**, while products without this designation demonstrate an equivalent negative value (**−\$9.15**). This indicates that Italian origin contributes positively to perceived product value and commands a measurable price premium.

For **online availability**, purchasing via the brand website corresponds to a positive mWTP of **+\$8.63** relative to the average channel, whereas purchasing through **online marketplaces** shows a negative mWTP of **−\$8.63**. This suggests that direct brand purchasing is economically preferred, potentially reflecting trust or brand authenticity considerations.

Overall, the mWTP results provide a monetary interpretation of consumer trade-offs relative to category averages. The findings indicate that material selection—particularly wool—and country-of-origin branding generate the strongest positive economic value. In contrast, synthetic materials, full colour designs, and marketplace availability tend to reduce perceived product value relative to the average alternative within their respective attributes.

3.7. Utility Heatmap



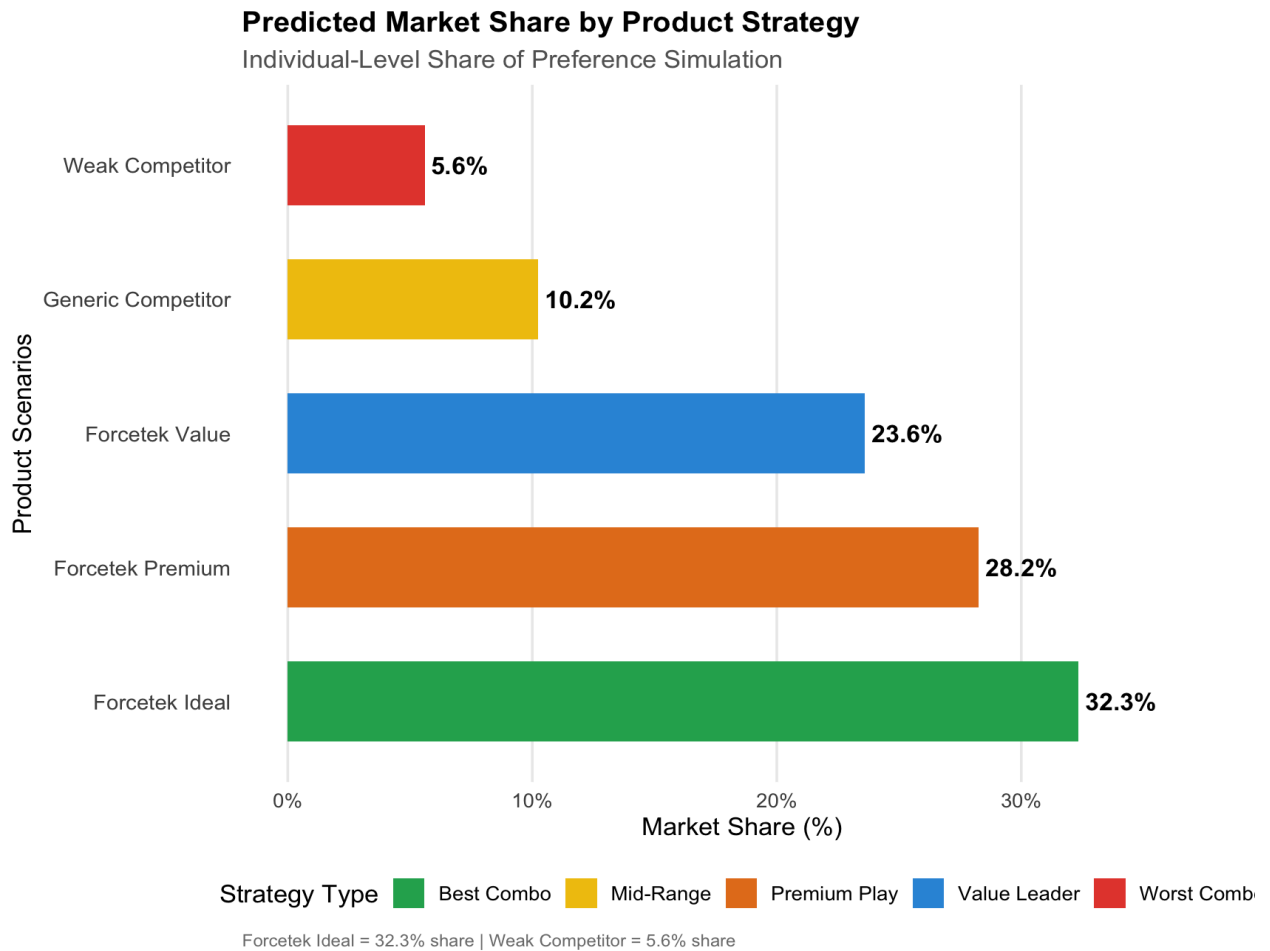
The utility heatmap presents the estimated part-worth utilities for each attribute level, where higher values indicate stronger consumer preference. The results confirm patterns observed in previous analyses. Lower price levels generate the strongest positive utility, while higher price levels significantly reduce product attractiveness. Among material options, wool and nylon demonstrate positive utility scores, indicating stronger consumer appeal compared to other fabrics.

Design-related attributes show that black jerseys with coloured trims produce positive utility values, while full colour designs reduce overall attractiveness. Additionally, products labeled Made in Italy and those available through brand websites demonstrate positive utility contributions, further reinforcing earlier preference and willingness-to-pay findings.

3.8. Product Strategy and Positioning :

The following Product Strategy simulation was conducted to better understand the market share of each, as follows:

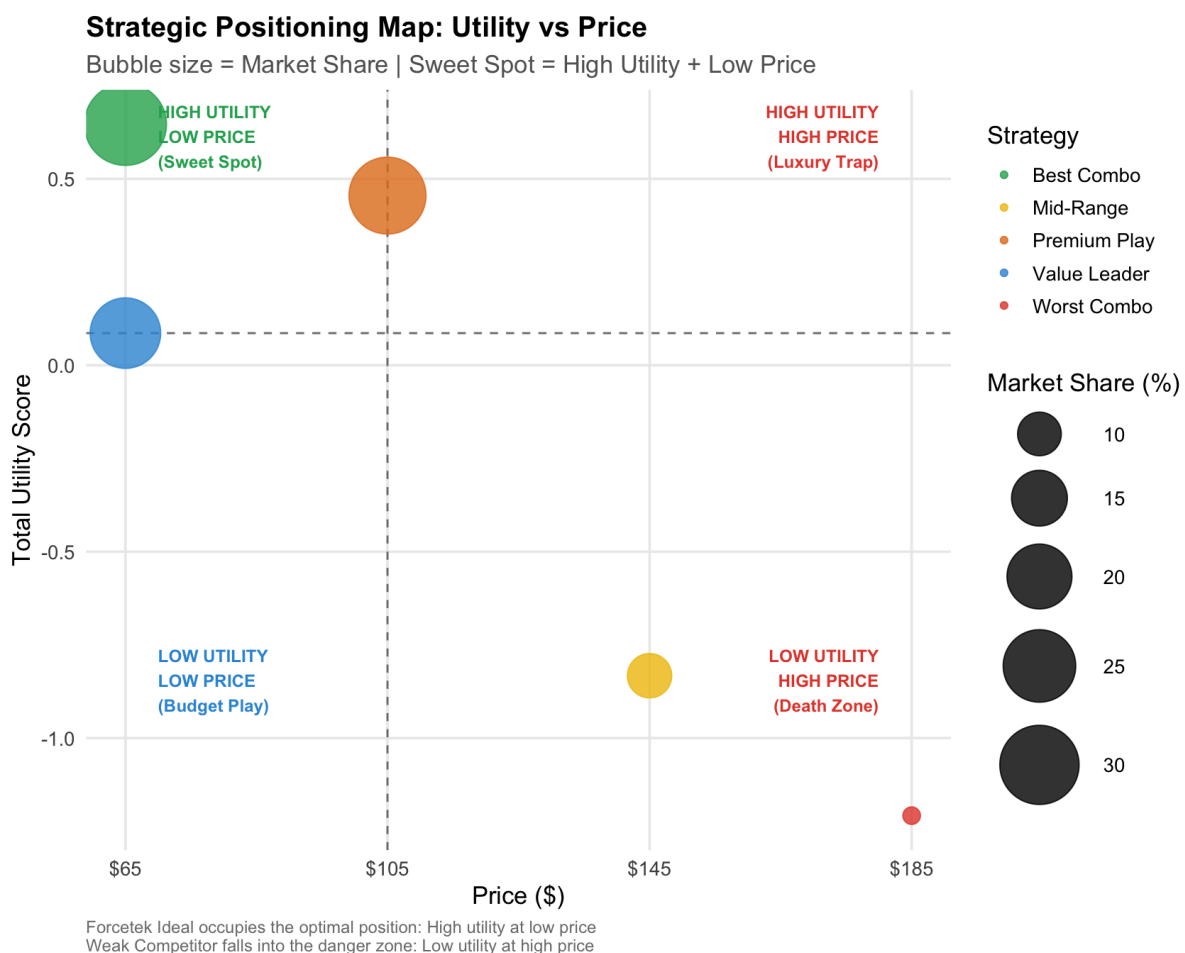
Scenario	Price	Main Material	Aesthetic Design	Origin (Italy)	Distribution
Forcetek Ideal	\$65	Wool	Full Color	Yes	Brand Website
Forcetek Premium	\$105	Wool	Black w/ Trims	Yes	Brand Website
Forcetek Value	\$65	Polyester	Stealth Black	No	Online Marketplace
Generic Competitor	\$145	Polyester	Stealth Black	No	Online Marketplace
Weak Competitor	\$185	Polypropylene	Stealth Black	No	Online Marketplace



The **Predicted Market Share by Product Strategy** bar chart summarizes the results of a "Share of Preference" simulation, which forecasts how different product configurations would perform against existing competitors.

The data shows that the **"Forcetek Ideal"** configuration is the clear market leader, capturing **32.3%** of the predicted share, nearly triple that of a generic mid-range competitor (10.2%). Interestingly, the **"Forcetek Premium"** strategy remains highly competitive at **28.2%**, while even a **"Forcetek Value"** approach secures nearly a quarter of the market (23.6%). This indicates that Forcetek's core attributes, likely its material quality and Italian heritage, provide a strong competitive floor, allowing the brand to capture significant share across multiple price tiers.

The **Strategic Positioning Map** explains the "why" behind these figures: the "**Forcetek Ideal**" configuration occupies the "**Sweet Spot**" where high utility meets low price. Crucially, the narrow **4.1% gap** in market share between the "**Ideal**" and "**Premium**" models reveals a vital business insight: Forcetek can significantly increase its profit margins by pursuing a **Premium Positioning** with only a marginal sacrifice in total market reach. By leveraging superior materials and craftsmanship, Forcetek successfully differentiates itself from the high-priced, low-utility competitors that dominate the lower end of the preference scale.



4. Conclusion

The results of the conjoint analysis reveal several important patterns in consumer preferences for men's sports jerseys, highlighting the relative importance of economic, functional, and aesthetic product characteristics.

One of the most significant findings of the study is the dominant influence of **price** on consumer decision-making. The analysis demonstrates strong price sensitivity across

respondents, with lower price points substantially increasing purchase likelihood. While moderate price increases remain acceptable for some consumers, higher premium pricing levels significantly reduce product attractiveness. This indicates that pricing strategy plays a critical role in maximizing market acceptance and competitiveness.

Beyond price considerations, **material composition** emerges as the second most influential product attribute. Consumers show a clear preference for higher-perceived quality materials, with wool and nylon generating positive preference and willingness-to-pay outcomes. These findings suggest that consumers associate certain materials with improved comfort, durability, and overall product performance, reinforcing the importance of material selection in product development.

The study also reveals consistent consumer preferences regarding **design aesthetics**. Minimalistic and functional design elements are strongly favoured, while visually dominant or full-colour designs demonstrate lower overall preference. This suggests that consumers prioritize versatility and subtle visual identity in sports apparel, particularly for products used in regular training and fitness environments.

Country-of-origin branding also contributes measurable value to product perception. Jerseys labeled as **Made in Italy** generate positive consumer responses and increased willingness to pay, indicating that origin-based branding can enhance perceived product quality and brand credibility. Similarly, purchasing through official brand websites demonstrates slightly higher consumer preference compared to third-party online marketplaces, suggesting that direct brand channels may strengthen trust and authenticity perceptions.

Overall, the findings indicate that consumers primarily evaluate sports jerseys through a combination of price accessibility, functional reliability, and understated design. The results suggest that optimal product configurations should balance affordability with high-quality materials and simple, performance-oriented aesthetics.

From a strategic perspective, the study supports positioning Forcetek jerseys as reliable, high-value sportswear products designed for regular recreational athletes. By aligning product development with consumer priorities identified in this research, Forcetek can strengthen product-market fit and improve competitive differentiation within the sportswear market.

4.1. Study limitations and Recommendations

Although the findings provide valuable insights into consumer preferences, several limitations should be considered when interpreting the results.

The majority of respondents identified themselves as recreational or moderately active athletes rather than professional sports participants. For this reason, the results may underrepresent preferences related to high-performance or specialized athletic requirements. It is also crucial to remember that the geographical location of our respondents can have somewhat of a different outcome on preferences, compared to the purely Italian market.

It is important to take into consideration that conjoint analysis relies on hypothetical purchase scenarios rather than actual purchase behaviour. Although this method is widely used and reliable for estimating preference trade-offs, real-world purchasing decisions may be influenced by additional factors such as brand familiarity, promotions, or social influences.

Finally, the study focuses on a selected set of product attributes. While these attributes were chosen based on their relevance to sportswear purchasing decisions, additional factors such as sustainability, brand reputation, or product customization options could further influence consumer preferences and may be considered in future research.

THE END

References:

La Griffe srl. (2024). *Forcetek: Technical Apparel Division – Official Brand Profile and Heritage*. Retrieved from <https://lagriffesrl.com>